kilometers) per hour surfaced, proceeding at 15 knots while submerged and 9 knots snorkeling.

Theoretically, the vessels could remain submerged up to ten days, but their speed would then be reduced to no more than 2 knots. The problem was the lack of electrical battery capacity. In order to recharge its batteries, the submarine had to surface. The designers tried to deal with the problem as best they could by increasing battery space to take up two decks of the submarine, making the Foxtrot extremely crowded for the crew, even by the standards of the time. The nuclear-powered Hotel-class submarines were much better suited to transatlantic crossings, as they could attain higher speeds and, most important, did not need to surface in order to recharge their batteries. But as Arkhipov could attest personally, the Hotel-class vessels had numerous problems with their nuclear reactors and were not ready yet to undertake long voyages.[5]

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THE FOXTROTS LEFT THEIR SUPERSECRET ADVANCE BASE IN Saida Bay near Murmansk at 4:00 a.m. local time on October 1. One day before departure, the commanding officers of the navy removed the commander of submarine B-59, which would become the lead vessel of the group, and replaced him with Valentin Savitsky. Arkhipov, the commander of the group, also came on board.

Like the personnel of Soviet cargo ships bound for Cuba, the captains and crews of the submarines did not know their final destination. Special envelopes with directions would be opened only when they reached the Barents Sea, and their contents would be revealed to the crews only after the vessels had passed through the Greenland–Iceland–United Kingdom Gap, which served as one of the antisubmarine defense barriers of the NATO countries. One of the captains of Arkhipov's Foxtrot group, Captain Second Grade Aleksei Dubivko, recalled a meeting with the senior commanders of the Soviet Northern Fleet: "We did not receive answers to the following questions: 'Where are our vessels going?' 'Our sailing areas?' 'What is the general situation in the areas to which we will be sailing?' "